itself, cannot always be an assured basis for international peace and security. Re-globalization in an open-ended techade will call for trusted collaborations of a kind that will be a new experience for all of us.

SAGA OF A RISING POWER

It is this scenario that confronts India and the world as they both contemplate and calculate. We are heading into volatility and upheaval, where mitigation and navigation go side by side. In fact, the transformation that we long speculated about is now actually upon us. Externally, India is discovering the merits of converging with like-minded nations, even while maintaining its distinct identity. Its domestic journey enables it to offer new terms of engagement to a growing range of partners. As the most populous nation and currently the fifth largest economy, its salience is underlined by the manner in which it conducted the G20 presidency. The interaction between a changing India and a more dynamic world is clearly novel for both of them. In that situation, the quality of its leadership will make the difference. I have sought to capture the various happenings of a world under exceptional stress and present them as trends against which we assess India's prospects. Like my previous effort, this too is intended to contribute to an ongoing debate in an argumentative society.

Major nations that make an impact on the world do so after a defining event. It could be a conflict, a revolution or a major economic shift. Underlying all of them are both a jump in capacities and the character traits of a new player at that level. In India's case, its early diplomacy was eventually constrained by the capability factor. It may have shown up in national security and political challenges, but was actually a cumulative outcome of limited progress in socio-economic and technological fields. But somewhere, there was also the inadequate projection of a great civilization. India's progress has been more staggered than others in its peer group. Today, all these variables are coming together into play as India advances across multiple fronts in a self-supportive manner. Politics, economics, demography, culture and ideas make a potent combination. These deep changes across broad domains are contributing to the creation of the New India.

The last decade has witnessed an expansion of India's space and a rise in its international profile. The *mandala* of its diplomacy has taken a clear